

UPSC Civil Services (Main) Simulation GS-IV

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

Q1. (a) "Values without institutional support will soon be weakened and dissipated." Examine this proposition with reference to Indian public administration. (b) Distinguish ethics from morality. Why does the distinction matter to a public servant?

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (244 words; practice model, not official): (a) The proposition, drawn from the Second ARC's Fourth Report, holds that values are necessary but perishable, and that institutions supply the container which gives them shape and content. Indian experience supports it. Two districts recruiting from the same cadre and academy can differ sharply in grievance redress; the variable is rarely the officers' values and usually the container - published timelines, a functioning review meeting and a supervisor who reads the pendency list. The Commission's own observation that corruption fell where competition, transparency and computerisation removed discretion points the same way: incentives changed, characters did not. The proposition must not be read as dismissing character. The same paragraph insists values are needed as guiding stars and exist in abundance in our society. (b) Ethics is the systematic, reasoned examination of standards of right conduct; morality is the set of beliefs and practices a person or community actually holds. The words overlap in ordinary use, but the distinction matters because a widespread practice is not thereby justified. For a public servant, morality explains why colleagues treat a festival gift, a political recommendation or preferential treatment as normal. Ethics asks a further question: is the conduct fair, compatible with public duty, non-harmful and publicly defensible? A revenue officer cannot prioritise a relative's mutation file merely because family loyalty is socially valued; public office requires impartiality and equal access. The distinction must not become contempt for community values, which often reveal genuine hardship and guide humane delivery.

Q2. (a) "Refugees should not be turned back to the country where they would face persecution or human right violation." Examine the statement with reference to ethical dimension being violated by the nation claiming to be democratic with open society. (b) Discuss the claim that emotional intelligence is the ability to make emotions work for you rather than against you, with reference to a civil servant's capacity to manage conflicting personal and professional duties during a crisis.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (274 words; practice model, not official): (a) Returning a person to a place where life or freedom faces persecution violates dignity, compassion, the right to life and the democratic claim that state power is limited by human rights. Refugee Convention Article 33 expresses non-refoulement for States Parties. Ethically, a democratic open society should not exploit a vulnerable person's lack of citizenship to expose her to foreseeable grave harm. The duty is not absolute naivety. States may verify identity, assess security risk individually and use fair procedures against genuine threats. But collective expulsion, stereotyping or return without hearing treats persons as instruments of domestic politics. Temporary protection, access to UNHCR processes and reasoned review can balance security with humanity. India is not party to the 1951 Convention or 1967 Protocol; Indian answers should therefore add Article 21 protection of non-citizens and avoid overstating unsettled customary-law conclusions. NHRC v. (b) Emotional intelligence enables a civil servant to convert emotional responses from liabilities into administrative assets. Self-awareness detects when personal grief, fatigue or anger is affecting judgment before a consequential decision is made. Self-regulation channels that emotion into composed, proportionate action rather than reactive force or paralysis. In crisis, conflicting duties are inescapable. A district officer coordinating flood relief while a family member is hospitalised faces simultaneous emotional claims. EI does not eliminate the conflict but makes it navigable: the officer names the competing demands (awareness), maintains operational composure (regulation), communicates honestly with family and team (social skill), and delegates command temporarily if needed. The limit is real. EI provides the psychological infrastructure for managing competing duties but does not itself determine which duty takes priority - that requires a moral and legal framework.

Q3. (a) "Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in the society." In your opinion, what measures can be adopted to uplift the core values in the society? (b) Besides domain knowledge, a public official needs innovativeness and creativity of a high order while resolving ethical dilemmas. Discuss with suitable example.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (273 words; practice model, not official): (a) Corruption reflects weakened honesty, fairness, responsibility, empathy and respect for public goods, but values do not fail in a vacuum. When opaque discretion, scarcity, impunity and social admiration of illicit wealth reward misconduct, decent individuals face pressure to conform. Value uplift therefore needs family and school modelling of honesty, civic education about shared resources, ethical leadership, professional training and public recognition of clean

service. Institutions must make values practicable through simple entitlements, published criteria, fair pay and workload, conflict controls, e-procurement, protected reporting, independent audit and swift but fair consequence. Citizens coerced into paying for lawful services need protection and restoration, not equal moral blame with collusive beneficiaries. Community monitoring and social audit can turn public money into a visible common trust. Yet moral lectures without redesign breed cynicism, while surveillance without values breeds fear. (b) Innovation helps an official avoid false binaries without evading ethical constraints. In flood relief, a collector can use mobile verification, community lists, assisted offline help and a time-bound appeal desk when documents are destroyed, instead of choosing between total exclusion and fabricated records. Creativity widens feasible options; it does not create authority to favour individuals, hide reasons or bypass rights. The officer must confirm delegated authority, identify vulnerable groups, apply the alternative equally to comparable claimants and disclose the temporary criteria. Consultation with local bodies can expose error, while audit trails protect against duplication and capture. The measure should have a clear review date and normal safeguards should be restored when emergency conditions end. Thus ethical innovation is principled, evidence-responsive problem-solving: it reconciles service delivery with integrity rather than treating compassion as a licence for irregularity.

Q4. (a) "Non-performance of duty by a public servant is a form of corruption". Do you agree with this view? Justify your answer. (b) Administrative AI should support judgment without becoming an unanswerable final decision-maker. Examine with suitable safeguards.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (265 words; practice model, not official): (a) I agree conditionally. Public office carries a duty to use authority and resources for the authorised public purpose. Wilful inaction can function like active corruption when an officer delays a lawful service to extract payment, ignores collusive overbilling, permits a connected contractor to default or deliberately leaves funds idle for partisan advantage. The citizen loses entitlement and the wrongdoer gains protection even without a visible cash transfer. However, every poor result is not corruption. Delay may arise from inadequate staff, conflicting law, genuine uncertainty or a good-faith decision that later fails. These may require capacity repair, not stigma or punishment. The correct test asks whether duty was clear, the officer had capacity and knowledge, the omission was wilful or grossly negligent, an improper advantage or foreseeable public harm followed, and reasons were concealed. (b) Administrative AI can improve speed, consistency, anomaly detection and allocation of scarce inspection capacity. A welfare department may use it to flag unusual claims for human review. However, machine output reflects chosen data, labels, objectives and deployment conditions. It may reproduce exclusion, hallucinate, drift or omit context. Automation bias then makes a recommendation appear objective, while accountability is diffused among vendor, procurer and official. The ethical position is decision support under human responsibility. Before procurement, the department should define purpose, rights impact and success criteria. It should require representative testing, security and bias red-teaming, documentation, audit access and an exit route. Deployment needs meaningful human authority to depart, intelligible reasons, notice of automation, correction of data, appeal and continuous monitoring. High-stakes decisions should never rest solely on unverified generative output.

Q5. (a) "Life doesn't make any sense without interdependence. We need each other, and the sooner we learn that, it is better for us all." - Erik Erikson. What does this quotation mean to you? (b) Apart from intellectual competency and moral qualities, empathy and compassion are some of the other vital attributes that facilitate the civil servants to be more competent in tackling the crucial issues or taking critical decisions. Explain with suitable illustrations.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (262 words; practice model, not official): (a) The quotation rejects the fiction that individuals or institutions flourish in isolation. Human development depends on relationships of care, recognition, cooperation and reciprocal responsibility. In administration, interdependence means that authority, expertise and implementation are distributed across citizens, departments and levels of government. Disaster relief illustrates this clearly. A district collector needs local communities for information, health workers for triage, police for access, civil society for last-mile support and neighbouring districts for logistics. Treating beneficiaries merely as passive recipients wastes local knowledge and weakens trust. Cooperative federalism and participatory governance are institutional expressions of the same insight. Interdependence does not erase personal accountability; each actor remains responsible for assigned duties. Nor should the answer be diverted into 'learning and acceptance,' which is not the printed quotation. (b) Intellectual competence identifies legal options and technical consequences; moral qualities supply integrity and impartiality. Empathy adds knowledge of how a decision is experienced by another person, while compassion creates a disciplined motivation to reduce avoidable suffering. Together they improve both diagnosis and implementation. A technically correct online pension system may exclude an elderly claimant after biometric failure. An empathetic officer anticipates this barrier and provides an authorised assisted or alternative verification route. During disaster relief, compassion supports priority access for persons with disabilities, while objective criteria prevent favouritism. In a hospital, listening to a distressed family can improve communication without altering clinical triage dishonestly. These attributes require boundaries. Sympathy cannot justify false records, waiver of mandatory safety or unequal favour. Competence becomes public-service competence when accurate judgment is joined to dignity, accessibility and solution-oriented legality.

Q6. Explain how the bona fides test protects honest administrative risk-taking without creating immunity for negligent or corrupt decisions.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (134 words; practice model, not official): The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and on the information then available, could have taken the decision in the organisation's genuine interest. It corrects outcome bias: a failed loan, procurement or policy experiment is not automatically misconduct. Protection depends on process evidence. Contemporaneous reasons, due diligence, expert consultation, disclosed conflicts, equal treatment and absence of personal benefit support good faith. Concealed interests, fabricated records, deliberate rule evasion or reckless disregard defeat it. ARC's warning that every loss need not become a vigilance case preserves managerial initiative. The test is therefore neither subjective intention nor blanket immunity. Screening should separate error, negligence and corruption; competent investigators should then pursue actual knowledge, benefit and collusion. A reasoned, evidence-based test protects honest risk while keeping culpable conduct accountable.

Q7. Examine how the three components of attitude can be targeted differently in civil-service training to reduce bias in service delivery.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (145 words; practice model, not official): The ABC model identifies cognitive, affective and behavioural components, each requiring a distinct training intervention to reduce bias. The cognitive component is addressed through factual correction: presenting officers with evidence on entitlements, dispelling stereotypes about beneficiary communities, and explaining legal standards of non-discrimination. However, correcting beliefs alone is insufficient because bias often resides in the affective component. The affective component requires experiential engagement: field immersion in tribal settlements, supervised interaction with persons with disabilities, and simulation exercises that generate empathy. Mission Karmayogi modules that use case-based learning target this layer. A probationer who lives in a rural community for a week develops emotional familiarity that a lecture cannot produce. The behavioural component is shaped through supervised practice: handling real citizen grievances, receiving mentor feedback on interpersonal conduct, and being held accountable for service timelines. Transparent work routines and citizen satisfaction feedback reinforce the behavioural shift.

Q8. A successful marketing executive in an apparel company is accused by a woman employee of workplace sexual harassment. Management initially ignores her grievance and later offers money for withdrawal of both the complaint and FIR, along with a written declaration exonerating the executive. Identify the ethical issues and the options available to the woman employee. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (198 words; practice model, not official): The issues are sexual harassment, managerial indifference, abuse of economic power, attempted suppression of evidence, retaliation risk, conflict between sales performance and dignity, and denial of institutional due process. The payment offer also seeks a false declaration, converting settlement pressure into an integrity problem. The employee may insist that the employer activate the Internal Committee, preserve messages and witness accounts, seek confidentiality and interim protection, continue the police process where she chooses, approach the Local Committee or competent authority if the workplace mechanism is absent or compromised, and obtain legal or counselling support. She should not be compelled to choose between workplace inquiry and criminal process because they are distinct routes. The employer must constitute and assist the committee, prevent victimisation, avoid predetermining guilt, and act on reasoned recommendations. The respondent must receive defined allegations and a fair opportunity to answer; protecting the complainant does not authorise a sham inquiry. Equally, commercial value cannot excuse harassment or institutional capture. Her strongest course is to reject coercive withdrawal, document the offer, use the Internal Committee with safeguards, and continue lawful external remedies as advised. Dignity, truth and fair procedure must prevail over both corporate reputation management and allegation-based condemnation.

Q9. You chair a tender committee for essential hospital equipment. A technically strong preferred vendor has supplied the department reliably for years, but its local agent is your former business partner and the tender specifications closely match that vendor's product. Evaluate the options and recommend action. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (259 words; practice model, not official): Stakeholders are patients, competing vendors, taxpayers, hospital staff, the preferred supplier, the local agent, the committee and the chair. The issues are actual or apparent conflict, possible tailor-made specifications, continuity and safety, competition, confidential information and public trust. The chair could continue after private assurance of fairness; disclose but retain the vote; cancel the process immediately; or disclose, recuse and obtain independent review of the specifications. Silence preserves speed but makes every later decision suspect. Disclosure without recusal may not cure a material former financial relationship. Automatic cancellation wastes time and may disrupt essential care before facts are tested. I would file a complete written disclosure, cease contact with the agent and recuse from specification and evaluation decisions. The competent authority should appoint an independent chair and technical reviewers. They should test whether each specification follows patient need and interoperability or unnecessarily excludes equivalent products. Any change must be notified

equally, with adequate bid time. Existing evaluation data and electronic logs should be preserved. If only that product can safely meet a documented need, a lawful limited-competition route may be used with market-price benchmarking, recorded reasons, higher approval and post-award audit. If specifications were manipulated, the tender should be corrected or reissued and supported misconduct referred through due process. Urgent interim supply should be narrow, time-bound and separately approved. The recommendation protects both procedure and public purpose. It does not punish a reliable vendor merely for association, nor permit reliability to become inherited entitlement. Recusal, independent technical judgment, equal information, review and continuity safeguards produce a defensible patient-centred result.

Q10. Sunil, a young civil servant confronting an illegal sand-mining mafia supported by local functionaries and insiders, faces threats to himself and surveillance of his family. Identify his options, critically evaluate them, and select the most appropriate course of action. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (196 words; practice model, not official): Sunil can withdraw, seek transfer, continue alone, negotiate informally, or build a protected institutional response. Withdrawal rewards coercion and harms communities; transfer may protect family but leaves the network intact. Acting alone shows courage but creates avoidable safety and evidence risks. Informal compromise is unacceptable where organised crime and official collusion are involved. He should document threats and operational facts, secure evidence outside the compromised office, inform senior police and administrative authorities in writing, request assessed protection for family and witnesses, rotate sensitive personnel, and form a multi-agency team covering mining, transport, revenue, police and financial trails. Insider access should be restricted through need-to-know controls and access logs. Raids must remain lawful, intelligence-led and supervised. If local channels are captured, Sunil should use higher vigilance or authorised anti-corruption routes and seek judicial protection where necessary. Media disclosure should not be the first step because it may expose sources and operations. A transfer request can be reconsidered after evidence and continuity arrangements are secured, not as immediate surrender. The course combines courage with prudence. Integrity does not require reckless martyrdom; it requires sustained public action, institutional escalation, personal safety and an auditable trail that makes retaliation visible.

Q11. As a hospital administrator during an infectious COVID-19 crisis, identify and justify the criteria for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff, and examine whether the justification would differ in a private hospital. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (193 words; practice model, not official): The administrator owes duties to patients, employees, families and the continuity of essential services. Relevant criteria are clinical competence, urgency of tasks, infection exposure, comorbid vulnerability, prior training, availability of PPE, rotation and recovery time, voluntariness where meaningful, and the minimum staffing needed outside COVID care. Consequentialism supports deploying scarce expertise where it saves the most lives and prevents system collapse. Deontology prohibits treating staff merely as expendable resources: adequate protection, truthful risk communication, non-discrimination and reasonable accommodation remain mandatory. Virtue ethics requires courage joined with prudence and compassion. The process should publish objective criteria, train redeployed personnel, separate tasks by competence, provide PPE and insurance, rotate high-exposure teams, enable confidential health declarations and create rapid review for disputed assignments. Senior leadership should share burdens rather than transfer all risk downward. The ethical justification does not fundamentally change in a private hospital. Ownership may affect contracts, finances and referral networks, but dignity, worker safety, clinical need and professional duty remain the same. Profit or employment power cannot justify avoidable exposure. A private institution may coordinate with public authorities and recover legitimate costs, but the common ethical floor is transparent, proportionate and competence-based deployment.

Q12. A State proposes to integrate Citizens' Charters, a grievance portal and its public-service-guarantee law into one service-delivery system. Develop a lawful, citizen-centred and accountable model. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (243 words; practice model, not official): The model should preserve the distinct function of each layer. The Citizens' Charter should publish service-wise eligibility, documents, fee, responsible unit, realistic time and quality standards, accessible channels and ordinary grievance route. The service-guarantee layer should identify only notified services and reproduce the applicable statutory trigger, designated officer, appeal and consequence accurately. The grievance portal should register service failure, route it to the competent authority, provide tracking, record reasoned closure, collect feedback and enable lawful escalation. Integration should use a common service identifier. A missed charter standard should generate an alert; a grievance should draw verified application data without forcing resubmission; a statutory breach should move through the legal appeal route rather than be closed as an ordinary complaint. Citizens must see which route grants information, service correction, compensation or appeal.

Capability is the fourth operational layer. Map and simplify the process, remove duplicate documents, integrate back-end responsibility, train staff and preserve assisted, offline and accessible access. Data collection should be necessary and secure, with correction and human review for automated errors. Governance should track timeliness, accuracy, first-contact resolution, repeat grievance, appeal reversal, citizen feedback and group-wise exclusion. Independent sample audit should detect clock manipulation and premature closure. A cross-department service council should publish learning and revise standards after consultation. Penalties require statutory authority and fair process; capability failure should not be mislabelled automatically as individual misconduct. The integrated system succeeds when promise, redress, entitlement and capacity reinforce rather than overwrite one another.

Q13. Parmal is a small but underdeveloped district. It has rocky terrain that is not suitable for agriculture, though some subsistence agriculture is being done on small plots of land. The area receives adequate rainfall and has an irrigation canal flowing through it. Amria, its administrative centre, is a medium sized town. It houses a large district hospital, an Industrial Training Institute and some privately owned skill training centres. It has all the facilities of a district headquarters. A trunk railway line passes approximately 50 kilometres from Amria. Its poor connectivity is a major reason for the absence of any major industry therein. The state government offers a 10 years tax holiday as an incentive to new industry. In 2010 Anil, an industrialist, decided to take benefits to set up Amria Plastic Works (APW) in Noora village, about 20 km from Amria. While the factory was being built, Anil hired the required key labour and got them trained at the skill training centres at Amria. This act of his made the key personnel very loyal to APW. APW started production in 2011 with the labour drawn fully from Noora village. The villagers were very happy to get employment near their homes and were motivated by the key personnel to meet the production targets with high quality. APW started making large profits, a sizeable portion of which was used to improve the quality of life in Noora. By 2016, Noora could boast of a greener village and a renovated village temple. Anil liaised with the local MLA to increase the frequency of the bus services to Amria. The government also opened a primary health care centre and primary school at Noora in buildings constructed by APW. APW used its CSR funds to set up women's self-help groups, subsidize primary education to the village children and procure an ambulance for use by its employees and the needy. In 2019, there was a minor fire in APW. It was quickly extinguished as fire safety protocols were in place in the factory. Investigations revealed that the factory had been using electricity in excess of its authorized capacity. This was soon rectified. The next year, due to a nationwide lockdown, the requirement of production fell for four months. Anil decided that all employees would be paid regularly. He employed them to plant trees and improve the village habitat. APW had developed a reputation of high quality production and a motivated workforce. Critically analyse the story of APW and state the ethical issues involved. Do you consider APW as a role model for development of backward areas? Give reasons.

[30 marks | 350 words]

Model answer (241 words; practice model, not official): APW demonstrates an ethically valuable local-development model. It created nearby employment, invested in skills, retained workers during the lockdown, supported women's groups, education, health access, transport and environmental improvement. Fire-safety protocols worked, and the company corrected excess electricity use after investigation. These actions strengthened human capabilities and reciprocal trust rather than treating Noora merely as a labour pool. However, critical appraisal must separate outcomes, motives and governance. Loyalty generated by dependence can suppress worker voice. Liaison with the MLA should remain transparent and must not become preferential access. Temple renovation may be socially welcomed but CSR choices should be inclusive, needs-based and consistent with lawful Schedule VII purposes. Excess electricity use shows that community expenditure cannot substitute for compliance in core operations. Plastic production also requires credible waste and environmental safeguards, which the facts do not establish. APW is therefore a qualified role model, not a perfect template. Replication should retain local hiring, skill formation, wage continuity and community partnership while adding independent needs assessment, worker grievance channels, environmental monitoring, transparent CSR disclosure and periodic impact evaluation. Government must still provide public services and regulate the factory; corporate benevolence cannot replace state responsibility. The ethical lesson is stakeholder governance: enterprise success can support backward-area development, but legitimacy depends on lawful core conduct, inclusive participation and durable institutions, not only visible CSR spending. Community consent and published outcome indicators would also reduce the risk that corporate priorities quietly replace locally identified needs.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS